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Pursue Unity

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Pursue Unity

Today's Reading: John 17:20-26

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"I do not ask for these only, but also for those who will believe in me through their word, that they may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, that they also may be in us, so that the world may believe that you have sent me. The glory that you have given me I have given to them, that they may be one even as we are one."

* * * * *

When Jesus came to the Father in prayer in John 17, he not only

prayed for the disciples who were with him, but also for all who will ever believe in him. That includes you right now—if you believe in him.

Jesus' prayer for you has one specific concern: He wants all his followers to be unified. He wants them to be one in the same way that he and his Father are one. He is perfectly in the Father, and the Father in him.

When you receive Christ as Savior, he enters you. And if the Father and the Son are perfectly one, that means they both indwell you. That's an example of the unity they desire among all believers. When the world sees this unity being lived out, it will believe that the Father sent the Son to forgive their sins.

The Father and the Son desire all believers to remain unified. United we stand against the enemy, divided we fall. A kingdom divided internally cannot stand. We need one another to advance the Lord's kingdom.

A sports team cannot succeed if divided. Nor can a business organization. Nor can a marriage. There must be unity. Conversely, individual fingers can cause little harm—giving only a painless poke. But balled together, the fingers can become a fist, and a powerful force.

The devil's name means "the divider." He wants to divide friendships, marriages, and churches. He knows the power of unity. He knows defeat is difficult when believers stand together. That's why he desires division and uses every available tool

in his hellish arsenal to separate believers.

That's why Jesus instructs you to pursue unity with all your energy.

If you've hurt one of his followers, before you attend another worship service, drop everything and go reconcile yourself with that person.¹³ If you don't, then your worship will make a mockery of God's forgiveness freely given to you. He wants unity.

If someone has hurt you, pray for him to be blessed by the Lord. It's impossible to feel bitterness while you are praying for someone to receive God's blessings. Forgive. Be freed from bitterness. If possible, make every effort to be at peace with others. Jesus wants unity.

If your marriage is being threatened by divorce, fight hard to stay married. Your children will be hurt the most if you break apart. For the rest of their lives, they will carry around the scars of mom and dad separating. Plus, it's a terrible witness for Christ before a watching world. He wants unity.

Make every effort to guard your unity—in your friendships, marriages, and the church.

There's great power in unity, as the Father and the Son well know.

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, *Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC*]